

THE PRE-FLIGHT CHECKLIST

Before You Spend a *Rupiah* on Meta Ads

*Meta stopped letting you pick the audience.
Your creative picks it now. Here's what to check first.*

The game changed. Most ad budgets are still playing the old one.

For a decade, you picked the audience. Interests, lookalikes, age, gender. You controlled who saw the ad, and the creative just had to convince them.

That era is over. Meta removed most of that control this year. Now its AI **reads your creative** — the hook, the words on screen, the subject, the structure — and decides who sees the ad from there.

Which means your script isn't just persuasion anymore. It's a **targeting input**. And most of the money lost on Meta ads is lost *before launch* — on the five things below that almost nobody checks.

*Your creative isn't decoration on top of the targeting. Your creative **is** the targeting.*

HOW TO USE THIS

Run these five phases in order, top to bottom, every time you build a campaign. Don't skip to the creative — the foundation phase is what makes the creative phase work. Tick each box only when it's genuinely done.

Work the loop in order.

01

FIX THE SIGNAL — BEFORE ANY CREATIVE

Get your tracking right first

Meta learns from the data you send back. Weak data, and it can't tell who your ad actually found.

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- ☐ **Turn on both Pixel and CAPI.**
These are the two tools that send conversion data back to Meta. Running only one leaves the system half-blind.
 - ☐ **Push your Event Match Quality above 7.**
Send clean customer details (hashed email, phone, location). Higher match = Meta connects each sale to a real person more accurately.
 - ☐ **Pick one main conversion event — not five competing ones.**
Optimizing for the wrong or overlapping events attracts the wrong people.
 - ☐ **Tear down the old scaffolding.**
Stacked interests, layered lookalikes, age/gender exclusions — built to steer a system that no longer needs steering. It now just slows learning down.

02

SIMPLIFY THE STRUCTURE

Consolidate so it can learn

Fragmentation keeps every ad set stuck in the learning phase. Fewer, bigger buckets learn faster.

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- ☐ **Go broad. Fewer ad sets, one budget.**
Broad targeting gives the algorithm room to find buyers you'd never have picked manually.
 - ☐ **Let interests be hints, not handcuffs.**
If you use them at all, keep them loose. Treat them as a direction, not a hard fence.

03

THE FIRST 3 SECONDS — YOUR TARGETING INPUT

Make the hook say who it's for

This is the part that tells Meta what the ad is about, and who should care. Vague hook, wrong audience.

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- ☐ **Name the exact person and their exact moment.**
Not "our product is great." Say who it's for and what they're dealing with right now — out loud and on screen.
 - ☐ **Make it land with the sound OFF.**
Around 85% of people watch muted. Your message has to live in the on-screen text, not just the voiceover.
 - ☐ **Deliver the core message inside 3 seconds.**
Most top-performing ads make their point almost immediately. Whoever stays past 3 seconds is far more likely to finish.
 - ☐ **Run the mute test on yourself.**
Watch your own ad on silent. If the point doesn't come through, it's not ready to run.
 - ☐ **Ask one question of every hook: does it say WHO it's for?**
Not "is it pretty." If you can't tell who it's for, the algorithm can't either — and it'll guess with your money.

04

BUILD FOR DIVERSITY, NOT VOLUME

Make several genuinely different ads

The system needs real variety to find different people. Near-identical ads cancel each other out.

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- ☐ **Ship 10+ distinct angles — not 5 color swaps.**
Different hooks, formats, and personas. Variety is what gives the algorithm something to match.
 - ☐ **Avoid the look-alike trap.**
Ads that look or sound too similar get grouped as one — so 50 versions might only get a single shot at the auction.
 - ☐ **Make sure the offer can carry it.**
Answer four things fast: why this, why different, why now, why trust you. The algorithm finds the right people — it can't fix a weak offer.

05

LAUNCH DISCIPLINE — WHERE MOST PEOPLE SABOTAGE THEMSELVES

Hold the line, then read the right signals

The system needs time and clean signals to learn. Panicking early throws away everything it learned.

- ☐ **Don't touch it for 7–14 days.**
Swapping the creative on day 3 restarts the learning phase from zero. Set a budget you can sustain, then leave it alone.
- ☐ **Read hook rate and hold rate — not just cost-per-result.**
These tell you whether the creative is working before the conversion data fully matures.
- ☐ **Refresh every 1–3 weeks.**
Winners get served hard, so they burn out faster than they used to. Keep a pipeline of new creative ready.
- ☐ **Diagnose a slump correctly.**
Rising frequency with falling performance is almost always creative fatigue — fix the creative, not the targeting.

ONE LAST THING

If the machine can't tell who your ad is for, it will guess. With your budget.

WANT THIS RUN ON YOUR ACCOUNT?

This is the exact pre-flight I run across real client accounts before a single ad goes live.

If you want it diagnosed inside your own funnel, reach out — I take on a few operators a month.

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